5000 metres as Pakistani maps had started to claim it, and Pakistani mountaineering expeditions had begun to venture into the vicinity. The glacier represented a gap in the demarcated Line of Control. [19] At around the same time, there were growing concerns about Pakistan's support for the Khalistan insurgency in Punjab—an insurgency that led eventually to the assassination of Indira Gandhi. For example, Indian intelligence found firm evidence, which was presented publicly, of Pakistani support for hijackers of an Indian airliner and for terrorists that sought refuge in the Golden Temple in Amritsar in 1984. [20] In 1986, India planned Operation Brasstacks, a massive armoured exercise and war game in western India, which alarmed Pakistan enough to lead to a large mobilization on its side, including of reserves. [21]

Atomic Purgatory: The Nuclear Programme, 1967–1991

India's nuclear development both fuelled and was informed by the rivalry with Pakistan, but it had wider implications for India's domestic development and relations with the superpowers. The process of weaponization—the actual design and manufacture of a nuclear device—began in 1967–68, under Homi Sethna, Raja Ramanna, and R. Chidambaram. But by 1970, it was clear that India lacked enough weapons grade plutonium for a full-fledged programme, and absent diverting some from Canadian-supplied reactors (which could be used for peaceful purposes), India would require a decade to produce enough for a suitable deterrent. In 1971, Sarabhai told fellow scientists at an international conference that India was prioritizing the development of nuclear explosives, hinting that they had successfully developed a basic design. The building and operation by 1972 of the Purnima research reactor helped ensure that that year, the go ahead for a PNE could been given. The decision was a culmination of the technological progress that India had made until that point, the death of Sarabhai and his succession by Sethna, the consolidation of Indira Gandhi's political position after the Bangladesh